



‘IN THIS MOMENT, INDIA WON’T QUALIFY FOR THE NEXT WORLD CUP, EVEN WITH NINE SLOTS FOR THE NEXT EDITION. I WOULD LIKE TO BE WRONG ABOUT THIS’

Time to reflect: At the *Sportstar Goa Conclave*, Manolo Marquez, head coach of FC Goa, spoke about his time at the club and the future of Indian football SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

feel like I have the same problem that I had at Las Palmas.

Foreigners tend to take a liking to Goa and end up moving here. How have you taken to Goa and what have your experiences been like? Of course, I like it here. It’s the most European part of India. We arrived here during the monsoon. In the second week, I had to be taken to the hospital due to the extreme weather conditions. I felt bad initially, but now I am okay. I am very happy now in Goa. Now we have some days off, so I will explore the place with my staff.

You talked about how players don’t think when it comes to strategising on their own and are

very dependent on coaches. How do you go about countering that? It’s not just a problem in India. The game is changing; it’s very fast. It is played in 20-30 metres with a lot of players, and you have to think and use your brain very fast. If you don’t understand the game, it’s very difficult. If you play with a lot of space, even I can play with my tummy, being 55 years old. But if I know that I will be pressed while receiving the ball, you need to scan all the time, not only when you have the ball because you have players all around you. This is called understanding the game. Football is not just about playing with the ball; it’s about more things. I tell a lot of players at the top level that they can still improve by being professionals.

With Indian football, the larger conversation is always about when will India qualify for the World Cup. As someone who

knows about the reality up close, how frustrating is it for you? Even with the Asian Cup, the expectations are set at qualifying for the knockouts. Do you think Igor Stimac could have benefitted from more time in preparation before the Asian Cup?

We can speak for 100 hours, but the problem is always the same. We are speaking about this moment, and we have to stand still in this moment. In this moment, India won’t qualify for the next World Cup, even with nine slots for the next edition. I would like to be wrong about this.

We lost only 0-2 to Australia; we had a good first half, and then we lost 0-3 to Uzbekistan, and now everything is bad. It’s not like this. I repeat, it’s a long process, starting with the grassroots. It’s the same story with Qatar. When they got the World Cup hosting rights, they played Copa America matches in Europe, and then they were okay [for the